

05

Closed Spanish Foundations

The main tabiya, the purpose of h3, and how c3-d4 organizes White's position.



THIS VOLUME

6

deep lessons

12

lesson positions

30

course pages

You will reach the Closed Spanish knowing what each preparatory move prevents, creates, and delays.

LEARN THE STRUCTURE, THEN THE LINE

A four-pass method for a theory-heavy opening

1. DECODE THE POSITION

Read the board before the moves. Name the center, each side's break, the worst piece, the king-safety difference, and the race clock.

2. UNDERSTAND THE CAUSAL CHAIN

Every recommendation connects a cue to a reason and a consequence. If you know only the move, you do not yet know the opening.

3. PLAY THE DECISION

Generate candidates for the side to move, identify the opponent's strongest resource, and choose the resulting structure you can explain. The move is the end of the reasoning, not the beginning.

4. RETRIEVE UNDER PRESSURE

Cover the answer key, reconstruct the line, and speak the memory rule. Review after 1, 3, 7, 14, and 30 days, then test the idea in a slow game.

THEORY WARNING

This is a durable concept-first repertoire, not a claim to be a live engine database. Before tournament use, verify sharp forcing branches in Fritz or a current database.

Priority order at the board: legality and tactical survival, king safety, forcing moves, central transformation, activity, structure, then the remembered rule.

SIX LINKED LESSONS

Recognition first, execution second

LESSON 025 | PAGE 4

Decode: Why White plays h3*A prophylactic move earns its place by protecting a future plan.*

LESSON 026 | PAGE 8

Play: Why White plays h3*A prophylactic move earns its place by protecting a future plan.*

LESSON 027 | PAGE 12

Decode: The c3 support point*In the Spanish, pawn moves often reserve routes for pieces two moves later.*

LESSON 028 | PAGE 16

Play: The c3 support point*In the Spanish, pawn moves often reserve routes for pieces two moves later.*

LESSON 029 | PAGE 20

Decode: Maintaining the e4-e5 tension*Release the center when the recapture helps you more than the opponent.*

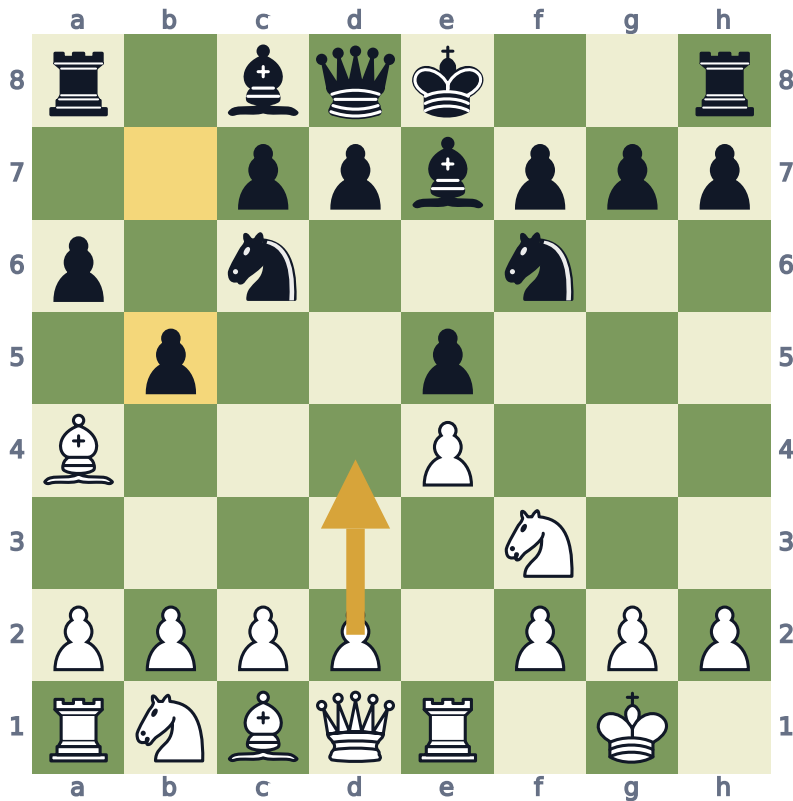
LESSON 030 | PAGE 24

Play: Maintaining the e4-e5 tension*Release the center when the recapture helps you more than the opponent.***VOLUME OBJECTIVE**

You will reach the Closed Spanish knowing what each preparatory move prevents, creates, and delays.

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Why White plays h3



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

h3 prevents ...Bg4 from increasing pressure on d4 and gives the king luft, but it also spends a tempo and slightly weakens g3.

DECISION RULE

Is ...Bg4 a real problem in this move order, and what does White gain by stopping it now?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

Black uses the tempo to reorganize and prepares ...Na5, ...Nb8, or ...Bb7 according to the chosen system.

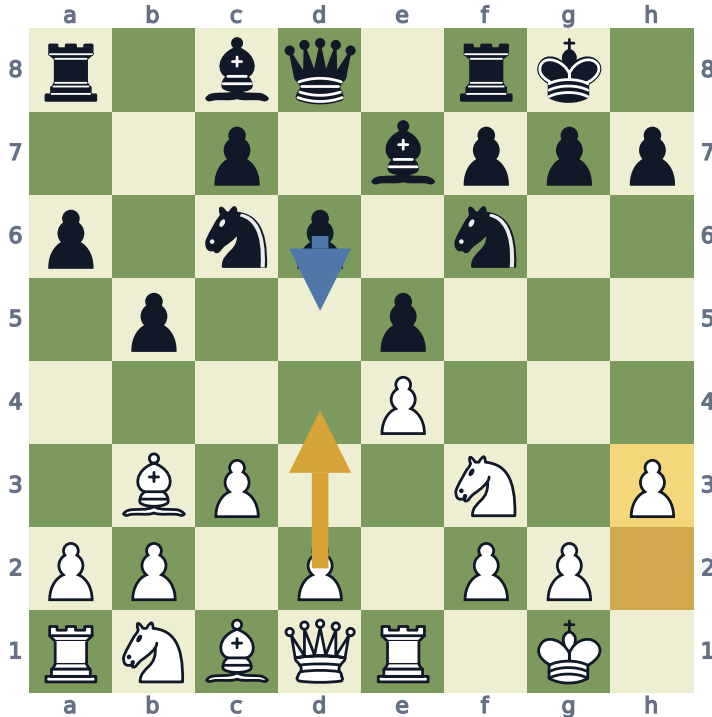
WHITE'S RESOURCES

White makes d4 easier and keeps the f3 knight free from a pin during central expansion.

MEMORY RULE | A prophylactic move earns its place by protecting a future plan.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

h3 prevents ...Bg4 from increasing pressure on d4 and gives the king luft, but it also spends a tempo and slightly weakens g3.

BLACK'S PLAN

Black uses the tempo to reorganize and prepares ...Na5, ...Nb8, or ...Bb7 according to the chosen system.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

WHITE'S PLAN

White makes d4 easier and keeps the f3 knight free from a pin during central expansion.

FAILURE MODE

Calling h3 useful without accounting for the development tempo it gives Black.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Is ...Bg4 a real problem in this move order, and what does White gain by stopping it now? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

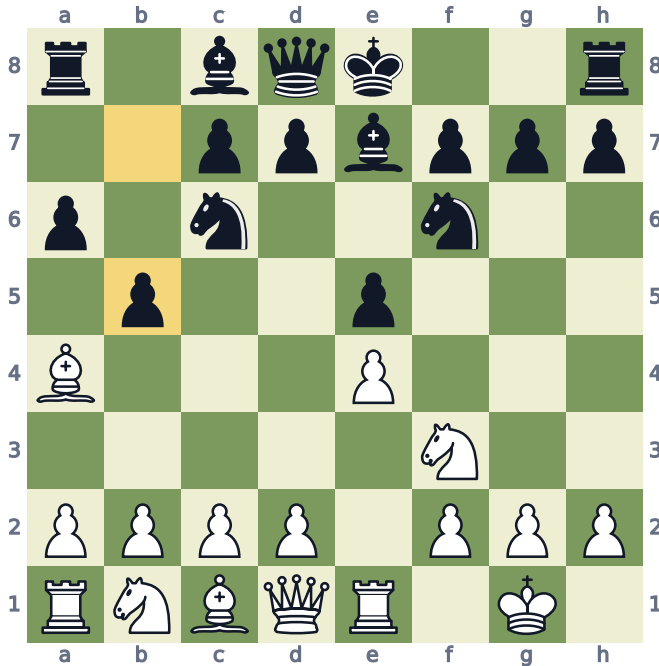
RULE | A prophylactic move earns its place by protecting a future plan.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. h3



- Ba4: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Nf6: Black reroutes a knight to f6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- O-O: White secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- Be7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Re1: White places a rook behind a file or pawn break expected to become important.
- b5: Black gains bishop tempo and queenside space while creating a possible pawn target.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

h3 prevents ...Bg4 from increasing pressure on d4 and gives the king luft, but it also spends a tempo and slightly weakens g3.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Is ...Bg4 a real problem in this move order, and what does White gain by stopping it now? White's resource is: White makes d4 easier and keeps the f3 knight free from a pin during central expansion. The line fails as a template when: Calling h3 useful without accounting for the development tempo it gives Black.

STORE THIS | A prophylactic move earns its place by protecting a future plan.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

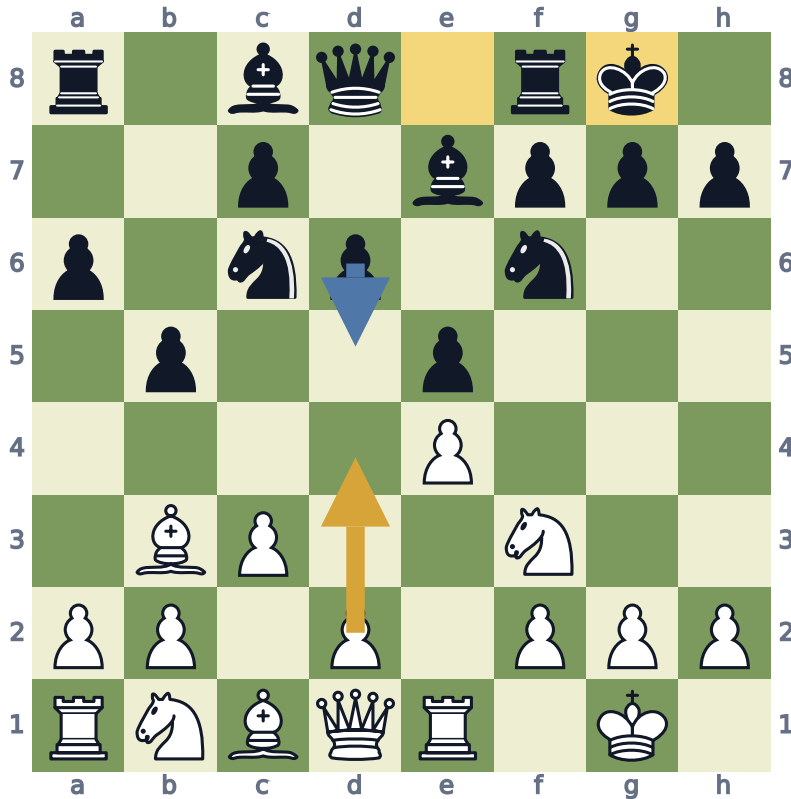
1. h3 prevents ...Bg4 from increasing pressure on d4 and gives the king luft, but it also spends a tempo and slightly weakens g3. 2. Black uses the tempo to reorganize and prepares ...Na5, ...Nb8, or ...Bb7 according to the chosen system. 3. White makes d4 easier and keeps the f3 knight free from a pin during central expansion. 4. Is ...Bg4 a real problem in this move order, and what does White gain by stopping it now? 5. Calling h3 useful without accounting for the development tempo it gives Black.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Why White plays h3



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

h3 prevents ...Bg4 from increasing pressure on d4 and gives the king luft, but it also spends a tempo and slightly weakens g3.

DECISION RULE

Is ...Bg4 a real problem in this move order, and what does White gain by stopping it now?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

Black uses the tempo to reorganize and prepares ...Na5, ...Nb8, or ...Bb7 according to the chosen system.

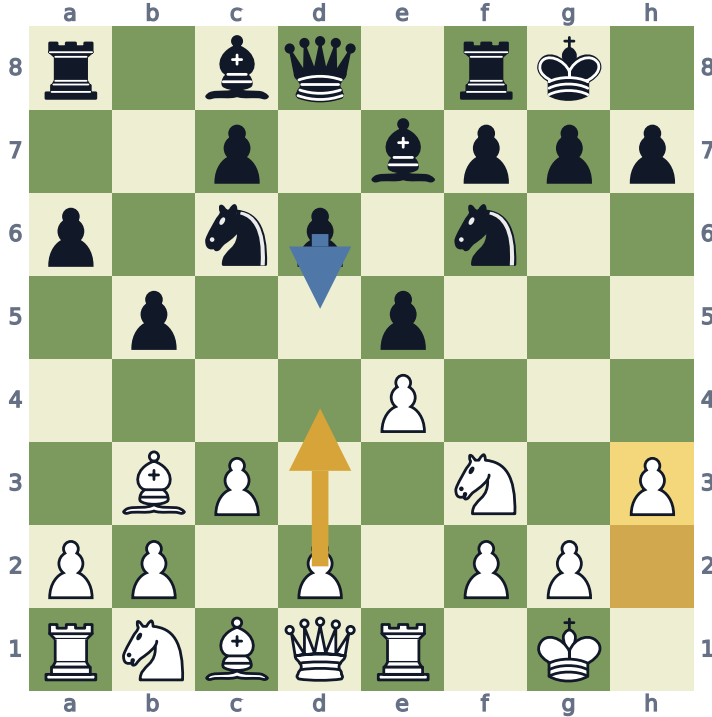
WHITE'S RESOURCES

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MEMORY RULE | A prophylactic move earns its place by protecting a future plan.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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BLACK'S PLAN

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

WHITE'S PLAN

White makes d4 easier and keeps the f3 knight free from a pin during central expansion.

FAILURE MODE

Calling h3 useful without accounting for the development tempo it gives Black.

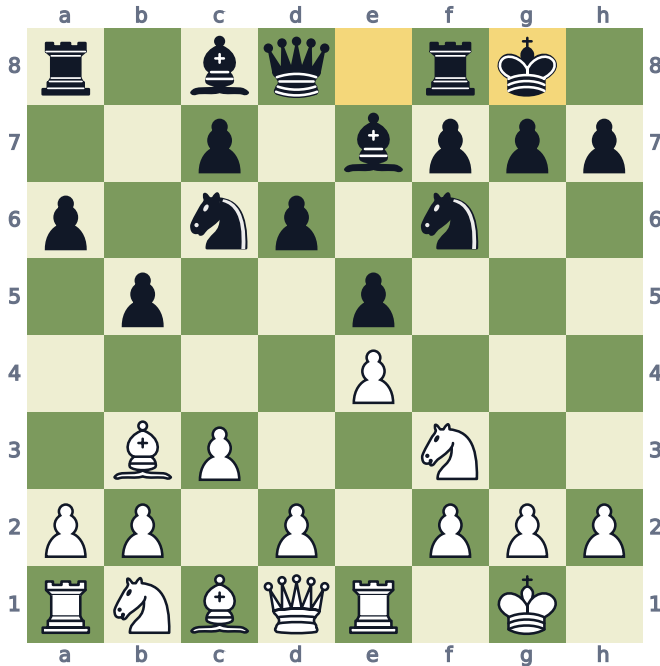
DECISION TEST

Ask: Is ...Bg4 a real problem in this move order, and what does White gain by stopping it now? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

RULE | A prophylactic move earns its place by protecting a future plan.

Move-by-move meaning

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. h3



- 10

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

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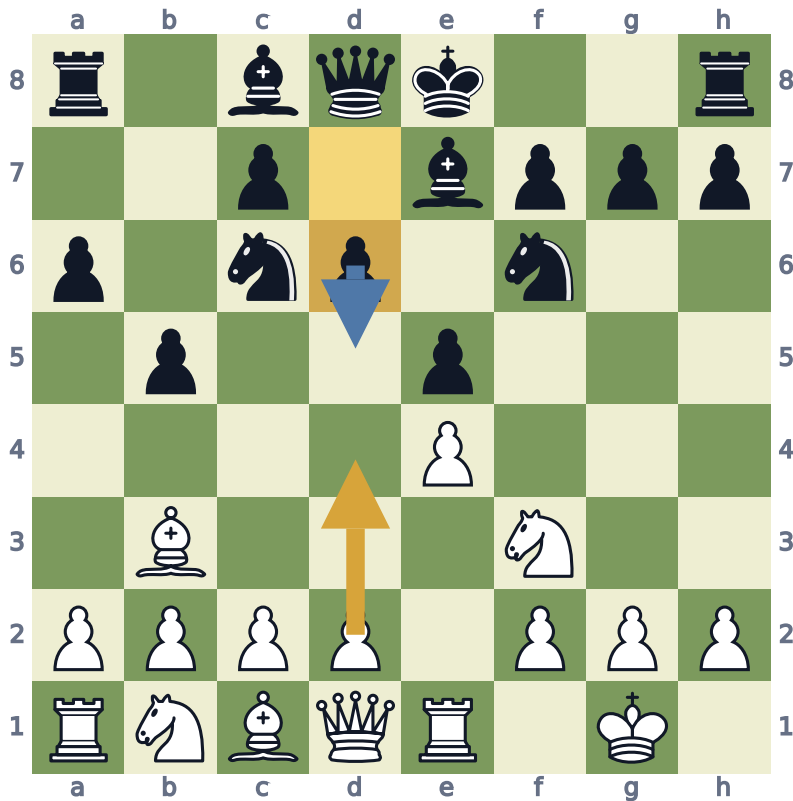
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: The c3 support point



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

c3 prepares d4, gives the bishop c2 after ...Na5, and controls b4 and d4; it also takes the c3 square from the knight.

DECISION RULE

Which future square does c3 reserve for the bishop, and how will the b1 knight develop instead?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

Black uses ...Na5 to gain the bishop pair or force Bc2, then expands with ...c5 against d4.

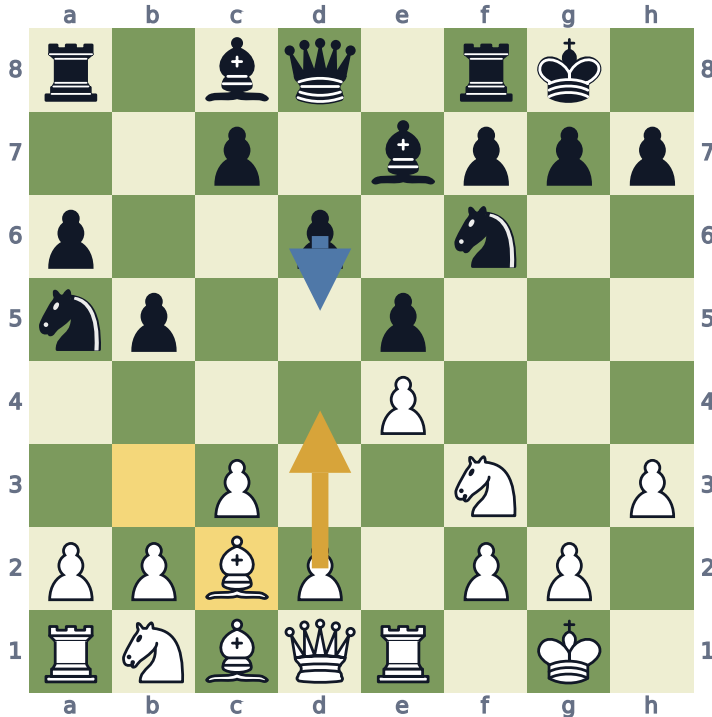
WHITE'S RESOURCES

White preserves the bishop and builds the d4 break with coordinated pieces.

MEMORY RULE | In the Spanish, pawn moves often reserve routes for pieces two moves later.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

c3 prepares d4, gives the bishop c2 after ...Na5, and controls b4 and d4; it also takes the c3 square from the knight.

BLACK'S PLAN

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

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WHITE'S PLAN

White preserves the bishop and builds the d4 break with coordinated pieces.

FAILURE MODE

Playing Nc3 and c3 plans simultaneously without noticing the square conflict.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Which future square does c3 reserve for the bishop, and how will the b1 knight develop instead? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

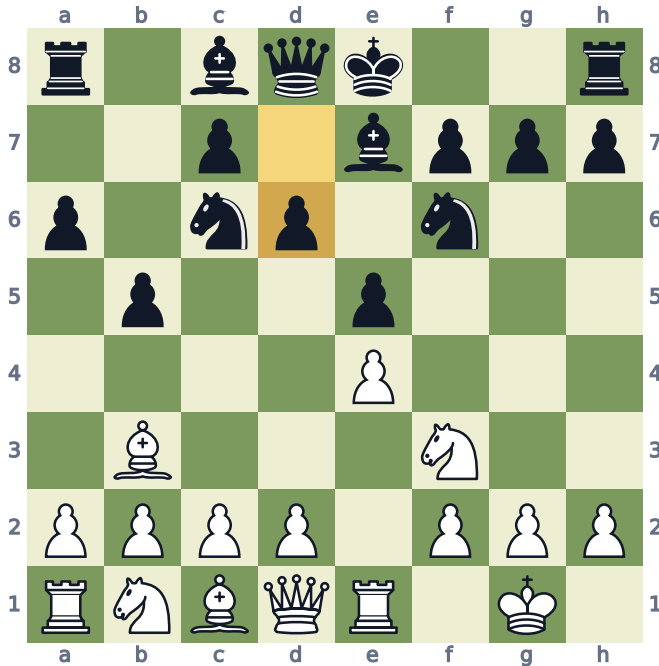
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

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- O-O: White secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- Be7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Re1: White places a rook behind a file or pawn break expected to become important.
- b5: Black gains bishop tempo and queenside space while creating a possible pawn target.
- Bb3: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- d6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

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WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

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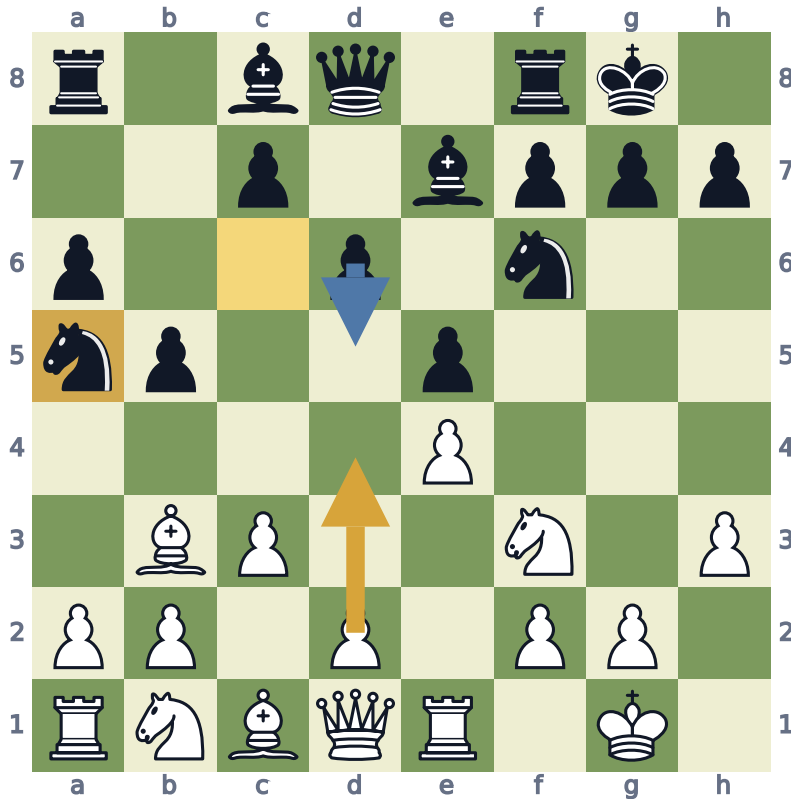
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 14 plies from memory, then replay: 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: The c3 support point



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

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DECISION RULE

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SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

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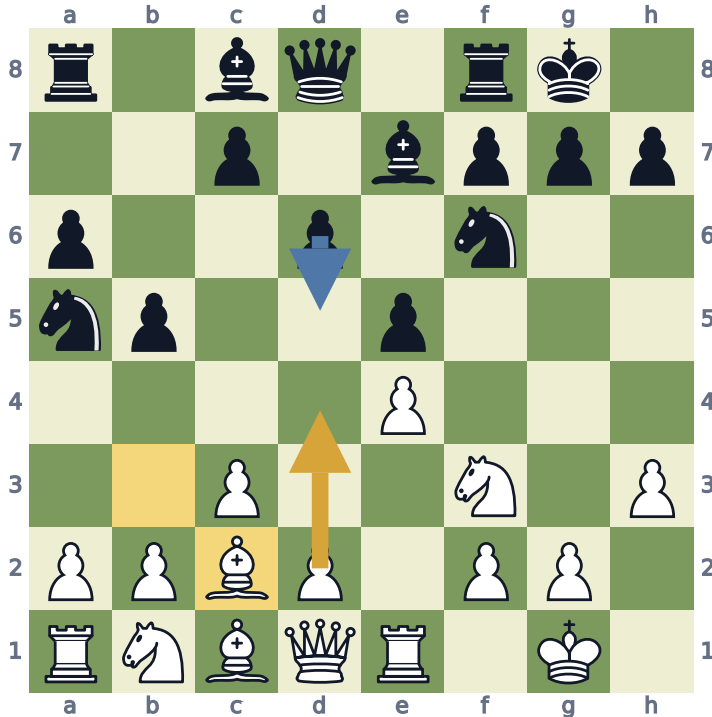
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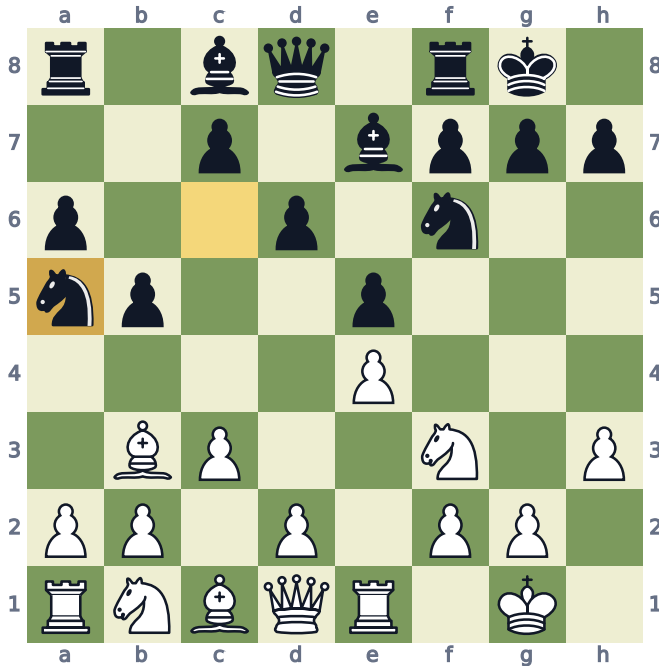
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Move-by-move meaning

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- Bb3: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- d6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- c3: White supports d4 and reserves c2 as a retreat square for the Spanish bishop.
- O-O: Black secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- h3: White prevents a pin and supports the coming central plan at the cost of one tempo.
- Na5: Black reroutes a knight to a5; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.

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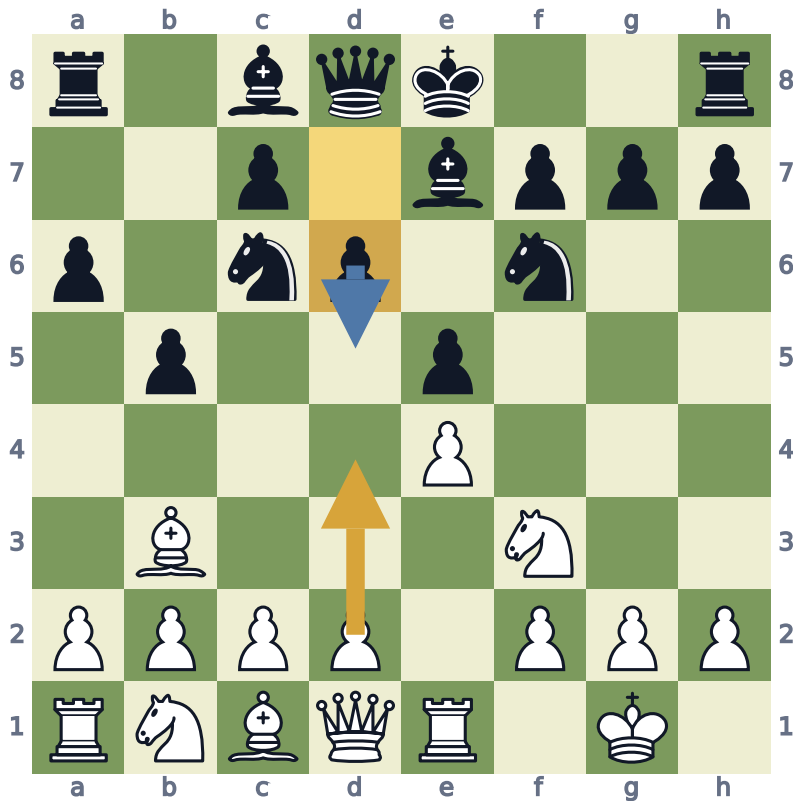
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 18 plies from memory, then replay: 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. h3 Na5

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Maintaining the e4-e5 tension



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Both sides delay capture because the recapture changes piece activity. White wants d4 with space; Black wants a version where exchanges free the cramped position.

DECISION RULE

Which side's worst piece improves after the central exchange?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

Reinforce the center and prepare ...Bb7, ...Re8, or ...Bf8 before releasing tension.

WHITE'S RESOURCES

White increases central control and may advance d5 to gain space if Black cannot break.

MEMORY RULE | Release the center when the recapture helps you more than the opponent.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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FAILURE MODE

Resolving tension to reduce calculation while giving the opponent a free developing recapture.

DECISION TEST

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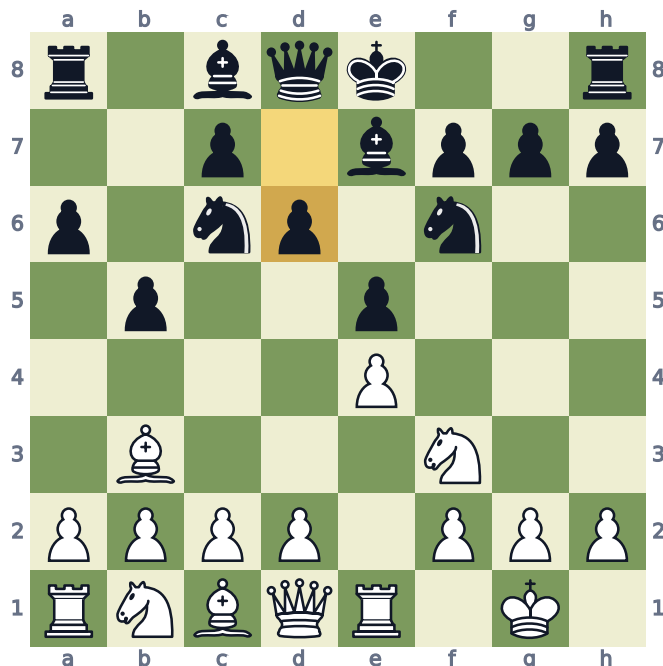
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Move-by-move meaning

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- O-O: White secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- Be7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
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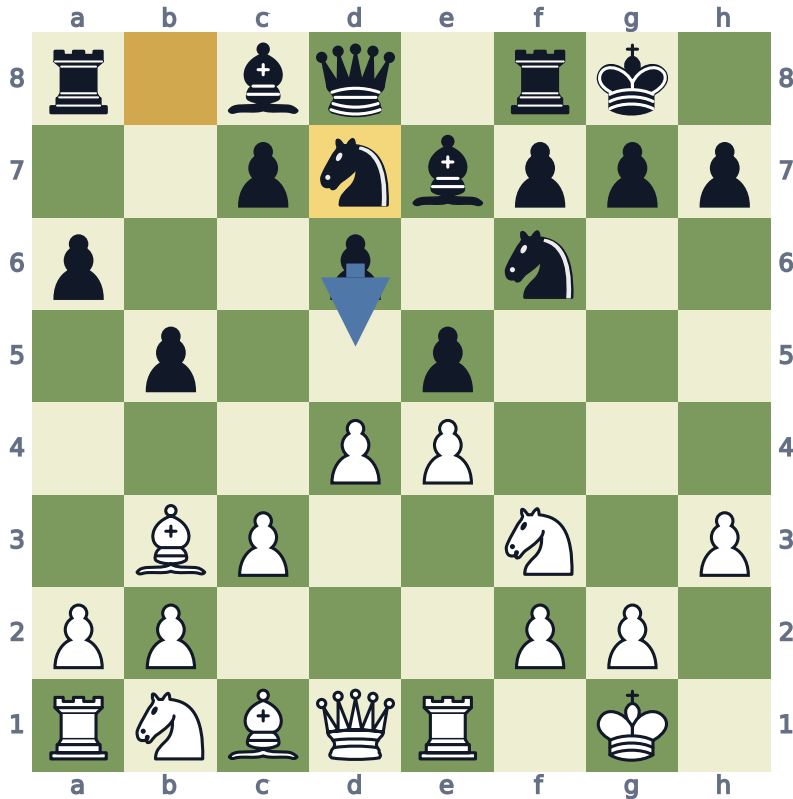
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 14 plies from memory, then replay: 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Maintaining the e4-e5 tension



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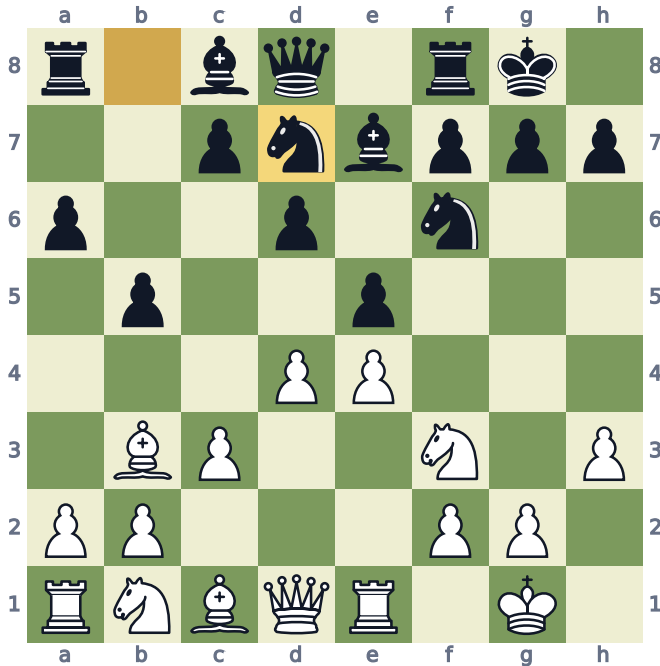
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- c3: White supports d4 and reserves c2 as a retreat square for the Spanish bishop.
- O-O: Black secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- h3: White prevents a pin and supports the coming central plan at the cost of one tempo.
- Nb8: Black reroutes a knight to b8; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- d4: White challenges e5 and opens lines after the preparatory pieces are ready.
- Nbd7: Black reroutes a knight to d7; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

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WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

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5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

1. Both sides delay capture because the recapture changes piece activity. White wants d4 with space; Black wants a version where exchanges free the cramped position. 2. Reinforce the center and prepare ...Bb7, ...Re8, or ...Bf8 before releasing tension. 3. White increases central control and may advance d5 to gain space if Black cannot break. 4. Which side's worst piece improves after the central exchange? 5. Resolving tension to reduce calculation while giving the opponent a free developing recapture.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 20 plies from memory, then replay: 8. c3 O-O 9. h3 Nb8 10. d4 Nbd7

SIX-POSITION TEST

Can you retrieve the plan without the chapter?

LESSON 025 Decode: Why White plays h3

Prompt: Is ...Bg4 a real problem in this move order, and what does White gain by stopping it now?

Recall: A prophylactic move earns its place by protecting a future plan.

LESSON 026 Play: Why White plays h3

Prompt: Is ...Bg4 a real problem in this move order, and what does White gain by stopping it now?

Recall: A prophylactic move earns its place by protecting a future plan.

LESSON 027 Decode: The c3 support point

Prompt: Which future square does c3 reserve for the bishop, and how will the b1 knight develop instead?

Recall: In the Spanish, pawn moves often reserve routes for pieces two moves later.

LESSON 028 Play: The c3 support point

Prompt: Which future square does c3 reserve for the bishop, and how will the b1 knight develop instead?

Recall: In the Spanish, pawn moves often reserve routes for pieces two moves later.

LESSON 029 Decode: Maintaining the e4-e5 tension

Prompt: Which side's worst piece improves after the central exchange?

Recall: Release the center when the recapture helps you more than the opponent.

LESSON 030 Play: Maintaining the e4-e5 tension

Prompt: Which side's worst piece improves after the central exchange?

Recall: Release the center when the recapture helps you more than the opponent.

PASS STANDARD

For each position: name the structure, Black's plan, White's plan, one candidate for the side to move, the strongest reply, and the failure mode. Score one point each; 30 of 36 is a pass.

THREE SCENARIOS TO STORE

One-page repertoire memory sheet

CARD 1

Why White plays h3

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. h3

Decision: Is ...Bg4 a real problem in this move order, and what does White gain by stopping it now?

Memory: A prophylactic move earns its place by protecting a future plan.

CARD 2

The c3 support point

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. h3 Na5 10. Bc2

Decision: Which future square does c3 reserve for the bishop, and how will the b1 knight develop instead?

Memory: In the Spanish, pawn moves often reserve routes for pieces two moves later.

CARD 3

Maintaining the e4-e5 tension

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. h3 Nb8 10. d4 Nbd7

Decision: Which side's worst piece improves after the central exchange?

Memory: Release the center when the recapture helps you more than the opponent.

Reconstruct each card from the final position, then from the opening moves alone.

SPACED RETRIEVAL AND GAME TRANSFER

Volume mastery tracker

Lesson	D1	D3	D7	D14	D30	Game	Pass
025 Decode: Why White plays h3	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
026 Play: Why White plays h3	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
027 Decode: The c3 support point	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
028 Play: The c3 support point	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
029 Decode: Maintaining the e4-e5 tension	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
030 Play: Maintaining the e4-e5 tension	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

TWELVE-WEEK CYCLE

Weeks 1-2: decode the three structures. Weeks 3-4: replay all lines from memory. Weeks 5-7: solve the workbook pages. Weeks 8-10: test in slow games or against Fritz. Weeks 11-12: analyze failures and retest the volume examination.

PROMOTION RULE

Advance only when you can explain every memory rule, reproduce the three reference lines, name both sides' strongest plans, and show at least one analyzed game where the decision appeared.

Do not measure mastery by pages completed. Measure whether the correct questions appear during a real game.